

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

The Boredom Basket

Open-ended play ideas · Ages 2–4

Children don't need constant entertainment. A basket of open-ended objects, plus a little patience from you, can turn 'I'm bored' into an hour of play.

What the research suggests

- ○ In experiments, people who did a boring task first came up with more creative ideas afterwards (Mann & Cadman, 2014).
- ○ Researchers describe boredom as a signal that pushes us to seek new activities and ideas.

Fill the basket with

- ○ Cardboard boxes and tubes
- ○ Old dupattas or cloths
- ○ Wooden spoons, steel bowls and katoris
- ○ Clothes pegs and a basket
- ○ Blocks, pebbles, shells (for children who no longer mouth objects)
- ○ Paper, crayons, tape

When they say 'I'm bored'

- ○ “I wonder what you'll come up with.”
- ○ “You can choose something from the basket.”
- ○ “I'm doing my work. You can do yours nearby.”
- ○ Then step back for 10 minutes.

What NOT to do

- ○ Rush in with a screen or a new toy
- ○ Plan every minute of the day
- ○ Fix their game for them

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Mann, S., & Cadman, R. (2014). Does being bored make us more creative? Creativity Research Journal, 26(2), 165–173.

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